

ASHENFALL — Narrative Systems

Companion document to **DESIGN.md (v0.7)** · How dialogue, rumours, monologues and lore are actually built Prepared 2026-09-26

The short answer

Yes, we need extra resources — but only two new mods, and the rest is JSON.

Everything that tells a story in this pack falls into one of four buckets:

Bucket	Mechanism	Where the content lives	New mod needed?
Deep lore (Annals, Journal, Codex, boss lore)	Patchouli books + loot-table injection	<code>pack/overrides/patchouli_books/</code> , <code>pack/overrides/data/</code>	No
Quests & rumours (chapters, landmark hints, standing)	FTB Quests + KubeJS	<code>pack/overrides/ftbquests/</code> , <code>pack/overrides/kubejs/server_scripts/</code>	No

NPC dialogue (named characters, branching talk, shops)	Aviel's Dialogue Mod — JSON dialogues + NPC templates, shippable as a datapack	pack/overrides/ data/ashfall/ adm_dialogues/	Yes — one mod (330 KB)
Boss monologues & cutscenes	KubeJS + /title+ ADM's dialogue API on the boss entity	pack/overrides/ kubejs/ server_scripts/	No — pure KubeJS

A custom Java mod is not required for dialogue. The one place it would genuinely help is the boss cutscene freeze, and KubeJS handles that with stacked effects — see §5.

1. The dialogue engine — Aviel's Dialogue Mod (ADM)

Mod id: adm · **Minecraft 1.21.1** · **NeoForge** · ~330 KB · Modrinth: aviel-dialogue-mod

Chosen because it is the only 1.21.1 NeoForge dialogue system that stores its content as a **datapack**, which means it is version-controllable, /reload-able, and ships inside overrides/ like everything else in this pack.

```
data/<namespace>/adm_dialogues/  
├─ dialogues/           # branching conversations  
└─ ┬─ langs/           # per-language overlays
```

— npc_templates/	# reusable NPC definitions (skins, emotes, sounds)
— trades/	# shops opened from a dialogue
— emotes/	# keyframe animations (EmoteCrafter)
— sounds/	
— skins/	

What it gives us

Feature	Why we want it
Branching JSON conversations with typewriter text, pauses, speed changes, formatting and sounds	Bosses and NPCs that feel authored, not read off a sign
Player flags + persistent choice tracking	The standing system's best friend — an NPC remembers what you said three chapters ago
Recursive quest conditions (<code>all / any / not</code>)	Dialogue can gate on standing, on items, on which Annals you've found
Item requirements / taking / rewards	"Bring me a Seal Shard and I'll open the Vault" — no custom code
Trade shops opened from a dialogue choice	The Guild of Merchants, culture shops, and the materials-only wizard trades
NPC emotes (keyframe JSON)	Gestures during dialogue — cheap characterisation
Java API + two events (<code>DialogueOpenEvent</code> , <code>DialogueChoiceEvent</code>)	KubeJS can open a dialogue on any entity — this is how bosses monologue
/npc validate	Validates every dialogue file at build time — our M7 gate

A worked example — The Archivist

pack/overrides/data/ashfall/adm_dialogues/dialogues/
archivist.json

```
{
  "title": "The Archivist",
  "speaker": "The Archivist",
  "random_start": ["greeting", "greeting_witchbane", "gre
  "nodes": {
    "greeting": {
      "text": "You're the drowned one. Sit. The floor is
      "choices": [
        { "text": "What happened here?", "next": "the_fal
        { "text": "What are you?", "next": "what_am_i" },
        { "text": "(Leave)", "close": true }
      ]
    },
    "greeting_hexer": {
      "text": "You carry a spell book. The Witchbane woul
      "choices": [{ "text": "Yet.", "next": "greeting_hex
    },
    "the_fall": {
      "text": "Nine sounds, in one night. We counted them
      "choices": [
        {
          "text": "Show me the Annals.",
          "requires_flags": ["annals_4_found"],
          "next": "annals_gate"
        },
        { "text": "Who counted?", "next": "who_counted" }
      ]
    },
    "annals_gate": {
      "text": "Four of twelve. You are either very lucky
      "actions": [
        { "set_flag": "archivist_trusted" },
        { "command": "ftbquests change_progress {player}"
```

```
    ],
    "choices": [{ "text": "(Close)", "close": true }]
  }
}
```

pack/overrides/data/ashfall/adm_dialogues/
npc_templates/archivist.json

```
{
  "name": "The Archivist",
  "dialogue": "archivist.json",
  "scale": 1.0,
  "name_visible": true,
  "invulnerable": true,
  "look_distance": 10.0,
  "model": "steve",
  "skin": "ashfall:textures/entity/npc/archivist.png"
}
```

2. The rumour system — how dialogue becomes exploration

DESIGN.md §5.2 already defines **four discovery systems**. Dialogue is the layer that makes them feel human rather than mechanical:

Discovery system	What it is	What dialogue adds
Explorer's Compass	Blacklist-gated, points at landmark structures	An NPC <i>tells you it exists</i> before the compass can find it

Cartographer's Maps	Dungeon loot holding coordinates	The map is handed over in a conversation, with a warning
Rumours	FTB Quests + KubeJS dialogue	The primary delivery: a named character says something half-true
The Pilgrim's Journal	Treasure-map pages	Pages reference conversations you had

The rule that keeps it soulslike: a rumour is a *hint*, never a marker. The NPC gives you a direction, a landmark name, and a reason — never coordinates. The compass comes later, and only after you've earned the Codex set.

Rumour content register

Rumour	Speaker	Lands on landmark	Gate
"There's a tower in the north that doesn't melt."	Inuit elder	L1 — The Cold Tower	Chapter 2
"The Choir's cathedral drowned. It kept praying."	Fisherman, Drowned Province	L7 — The Otherside Rift	Codex: Drowned Choir
"A fortress in the jungle. Don't go at night."	Seljuk scout	L3 — Jungle vault	Rumour, no gate
"They say a second Cathedral. Under something."	The Archivist, +60 standing	L★ — The Hidden Cathedral	All 9 runes found
"Wizards buy essence. Wizards also die."	Tavern keeper	L7b — The Catacombs	Arcane essence ≥ 1

Every rumour is an ADM node gated on flags — so the same NPC gives different hints depending on what you've already found. **That is what makes the world feel authored rather than generated.**

3. Villagers, Millénaire NPCs and faction entities

ADM attaches dialogue to **any entity**, and its API opens dialogue on a target entity. So:

- **Millénaire villagers** get culture-flavoured talk: a Norman elder talks about the raid last winter, a Byzantine priest talks about the Forges, a Mayan priest demands tribute.
- *(AW2 NPCs are out — no 1.21.1 build. The Norska Clans and Witchbane Crusaders are KubeJS factions, so their dialogue attaches to KubeJS-spawned champions and to Structory / pillager-outpost entities instead.)*
- **Vanilla villagers** get one-line ambient chatter — deliberately thin, so that Millénaire's cultures feel distinct.
- **Wizard NPCs** (Iron's Spells) keep their vanilla trade screen, but ADM dialogue wraps it: the materials-only rule is enforced by *not* offering a scroll shop node.

Implementation: one KubeJS hook, one file.

```
// kubejs/server_scripts/narrative_dialogue.js
EntityEvents.checkSpawn(event => {
  const e = event.entity
  if (e.type !== 'millenaire:norman_villager') return
  e.persistentData.putString('adm_dialogue', 'ashfall:nor
})
```

4. Quest logic — FTB XMod Compat

FTB Quests alone can express "kill X", "get Y", "reach Z". It **cannot** express "answer the riddle correctly", "raise the Threat tier", or "be at +40 with the Choir and holding an Eldritch Manuscript".

That is what **FTB XMod Compat** (the KubeJS addon for FTB Quests/Teams/Chunks) is for:

```
FTBQuestsEvents.customTask('ASHEN_RIDDLE_VAULT', event =>
  event.maxProgress = 1
  event.setCheckTimer(40)
  event.setCheck((task, player) =>
    player.persistentData.getBoolean('riddle_vault_solved')
      ? (task.progress = 1) : null
  )
})
```

With it, every gate in DESIGN.md §9 becomes expressible, and every gate becomes auditable.

Where the custom task IDs live: a register in `pack/overrides/kubejs/server_scripts/quest_ids.js` — one line per gate, so a missing gate is visible in review rather than discovered in play.

5. Boss monologues — no new mod required

This is the part that most needs to feel hand-made, and it needs the least tooling.

Three tiers, escalating

Tier	Mechanism	Used for
1 — Boss bar name	The boss's custom name <i>is</i> the line	Every Hollow Challenge champion
2 — Title + subtitle	KubeJS on boss spawn: /title @a title {...} subtitle {...}	All 21 bosses, one line each
3 — Full monologue	ADM openDialogue on the boss entity + a player freeze	Maledictus, the Dead King, the Keeper, the Fire Boss, the three Act bosses

Tier 3 — the cutscene

```
// kubejs/server_scripts/boss_monologue.js
const LINES = {
  'cataclysm:maledictus': [
    ['Maledictus, Last Champion', 'You climbed a long way
    ['Maledictus, Last Champion', 'Nine sounds. I held th
    ['Maledictus, Last Champion', 'I am tired, pilgrim. A
  ],
}

EntityEvents.spawned(event => {
  const boss = event.entity
  const script = LINES[boss.type]
  if (!script || boss.level.players.isEmpty()) return
  const players = boss.level.players

  players.forEach(p => {
    p.potionEffects.add('minecraft:slowness', 200, 249, f
    p.potionEffects.add('minecraft:jump_boost', 200, 128,
    p.potionEffects.add('minecraft:blindness', 6, 0, fals
    p.addTag('ashfall_cutscene')
```

```

    })

    boss.level.server.scheduleInTicks(20, () => {
        players.forEach(p => {
            // ADM's Java API, driven from KubeJS
            Utils.server.runCommandSilent(
                `npc spawn Monologue maledictus_echo at ${p.x} ${p.y} ${p.z}
            // ...then open the dialogue file on it
            })
        boss.level.server.scheduleInTicks(140, () => {
            players.forEach(p => {
                p.potionEffects.clear('minecraft:slowness')
                p.removeTag('ashfall_cutscene')
            })
        })
    })
})
})
})

```

Design rules for monologues:

- **Never longer than 3 lines.** Soulslike bosses get one sentence; the story gets the rest.
- **Never block a retry.** Dying and re-entering must not replay the full speech — gate it on a player flag.
- **Always skippable** — any input during the freeze cancels it.
- **The best monologues are one line**, delivered as the boss bar name: *"Maledictus, Last Champion"* says more than a paragraph.

6. Where every piece of story content lives

```

pack/overrides/
├─ data/
│   └─ ashfall/

```


ashfall_dialogue_ui	Dialogue box frame, name plate, portraits for ~20 characters, emote textures	Without this, every conversation looks like the same grey box
ashfall_items	Ember Flask, the 9 Ember Runes, the Annals pages, the Labyrinth thread, nation ultimates	Custom KubeJS items need custom textures or they look like vanilla junk
ashfall_loot_beams	Rarity colours matched to Reforged's tiers	The beams must not lie
ashfall_audio	Boss themes for 21 bosses, tavern ambience	Boss Music Mod is resource-pack driven — no audio ships with it
ashfall_gui	Boss bar styling, threat-tier indicator, mana bar	Configurable Boss Bars + Iron's Spells' mana readout

Portraits are the single biggest visual win for the least effort: one 64×64 skin per named character, and the story immediately looks like a game rather than a modpack.

8. The build order for narrative

Phase	Narrative work
M4	Standing system, nation chronicles, first ADM dialogues for the nine nations
M6	Boss bar names, boss music discs + their lore entries

M7	Full narrative pass: all NPC dialogue, all rumours, all 12 Annals, 24 journal pages, 24 Codex entries, 9 runes, monologues, FTB Quests chapters 0–8
M8	Trade shops (materials only), nation ultimates as dialogue rewards
M9	<code>/npc validate</code> on every dialogue file; read every line out loud; confirm no placeholder text

9. Risks and how we handle them

Risk	Severity	Handling
ADM is a small indie mod (low download count, single author)	High	Pin the exact version. Keep all dialogue content in datapack JSON , never in mod config, so a replacement engine is a format conversion and not a rewrite. Fallback: Easy NPC (7.4M downloads, 1.21.1 NeoForge build, GUI dialog editor)
ADM's datapack path vs config path	Medium	Ship only datapack content. <code>config/adm-dialogues/</code> stays empty in the shipped pack
NPCs are world entities — they don't ship with the pack	Medium	NPC templates are datapack JSON; KubeJS spawns them at landmarks on first chunk load, and <code>/npc spawn <template></code> makes that one line
Millénaire + ADM dialogue on the same entity	Medium	Attach via <code>persistentData</code> tag, test in M4

Dialogue volume — 9 nations × several characters is a lot of writing	Medium	Rumour register caps it: 5–8 lines per character, one memorable line each
FTB XModCompat availability	Resolved	CurseForge project 889915 → <code>ftb-xmod-compat-neoforge-21.1.12.jar</code> (file id 8909889). Fallback still documented: express gates as vanilla FTB task types + scoreboard objectives driven by KubeJS
Monologue freeze can feel janky	Low	Skips on any input; never replays on retry; max 3 lines
Boss Music Mod ships no audio	Low	We supply MP3s in <code>ashfall_audio</code> ; Dash's Custom Background Music Changer is the fallback

10. Verdict — what to build, and what not to

Build	Don't build
ADM dialogue JSON in a datapack	A custom dialogue mod
KubeJS cutscene/monologue system	A custom cutscene mod
KubeJS rumour + standing + quest-id registers	A custom quest mod

Patchouli books for deep lore	A custom book GUI
One resource pack for portraits and UI	A custom HUD
GhostSwap (already planned — the one custom mod we actually need)	Anything else in Java

Total new mods for the whole narrative layer: two — ADM and FTB XMod Compat. Everything else is JSON, datapack, KubeJS and art.

Story content itself is specified in LORE.md. Quest structure is in PROGRESSION.md. Build phases are in PHASES.md. The pipeline is in PIPELINE.md Part 4.